

IAA SETI Committee Report to Commission 1

1. Previous committee meeting

The IAA SETI Committee last convened in Sydney during the International Astronautical Congress (IAC) 2025.

The Chair's notes from this meeting can be accessed here: <https://>

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1. Updated IAA SETI Post-Detection Protocols

The Committee agreed to a significant update of the IAA SETI Post-detection Protocols. This was a major milestone for both the Committee and the wider field - the last update was in 2010. The new protocols were finalised after wide community consultation and a formal vote of the membership using an online Helios voting system. The result was an overwhelming endorsement of the new text. A white paper was developed for the IAA Board of Trustees, and they adopted it in May 2026. The IAA also issued a press release, which gained significant traction - two representative examples include:

<https://archive.ph/t0Ern>

<https://www.scientificamerican.com/article/steven-spielbergs-disclosure-day-gets-one-major-thing-wrong-about-the-search-for-aliens/>

This represents a major effort by the Committee and the Task Group that led this activity - M. Garrett (chair), L. Tennen, K. Denning and C. Oliver. The work started in 2022: Oliver et al. 2023, Tennen et al. 2024, Garrett et al. 2025. An updated paper describing this work will be presented at the upcoming IAC: Denning et al. 2026.

2. Preparation for the IAA SETI Symposium at IAC 2026

Abstract submission to the IAA SETI Symposium was again oversubscribed by a factor of 2-3. We have a strong programme of discussions on technosignature searches, post-detection strategies, and other emerging societal themes (e.g. researcher protection). Dave de Boer and Karen Perez will chair the SETI Science and Technology Session. Paolo Musso and Lori Walton will chair the SETI and society session. The symposium takes place on the 6th of October (morning and afternoon sessions). IP presentations on the 8th of October (13.30-14.50).

3. Next IAA SETI Committee Meeting at IAC 2026

The committee will meet at the IAC venue (1st floor, Hall 22) on Wednesday, 7th of October 2026, 10:00–13:00 local time (GMT+3).

A draft agenda has been circulated to the members. The main topics for discussion will be next steps regarding the new Post-detection Protocols (in particular, establishing a Post-detection Sub-committee) and a presentation of the new IAA Committee Terms of Reference. We will begin the process of electing new committee members after this meeting – there is a long list of people want to join – some members that are no longer active will need to roll-off the committee at the same time. Kathryn Denning and Steve Croft recently were elected as full members (academicians) of the IAA. There maybe others I am not aware of.

4. Recent Engagements/Meetings

Other meetings relevant to the committee in addition to the IAA SETI Symposium at IAC 2026 include:

- IAU Symposium (No. 404) on Technosignatures (2–6 March 2026).
- Europlanet Science Conference 2026, SETI Session & Splinter Session (Den Haag, 8 & 9 Sep. 2026)
- URSI GASS 2026 – Technosignature Session (Warsaw, 15–22 August 2026).
- Breakthrough Discuss, including a session on METI (Oxford, 20–21 October 2026).

The committee remains committed to fostering collaboration, dialogue, and policy development in the global Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence. The IAA SETI Community email list is a good way for people to remain engaged with IAA related SETI initiatives (community@iaaseti.org).

Mike Garrett, IAA SC chair.